Crispy Roast Potatoes

Large russet chunks are boiled in salted water with a little baking soda so the outsides fray into a starchy paste. The chunks are tossed in garlic-rosemary oil and roasted until that paste turns into a deep-brown crust, then finished with the fried garlic, rosemary, and parsley. Serves 6–8.

Ingredients

Russet potatoes . . . . . 4 lb.
Water . . . . . 2 qt.
Diamond Crystal kosher salt . . . . 2 Tbsp.
Baking soda . . . . . 1/2 tsp.
Extra-virgin olive oil . . . . . 7 Tbsp.
Fresh rosemary, finely chopped . . 1 Tbsp.
Garlic cloves, minced 3
Black pepper . . . . . 1/2 tsp.
Fresh parsley, minced . . . . . 1/4 cup

Directions

Heat the oven to *450°F* (*400°F* convection), with a rack in the center — Peel the **potatoes** and cut them into 2- to 3-inch chunks. Hold them in *Large Bowl #1* — Combine 2 Tbsp. **Diamond Crystal kosher salt** and 1/2 tsp. **baking soda** in *Small Bowl #1* (boil seasonings) — Mince the **garlic**. Finely chop the **rosemary**. Combine both with 6 Tbsp. **olive oil** and 1/4 tsp. **black pepper** in *Small Bowl #2* (infusion) — Mince the **parsley** and set it aside in *Small Bowl #3*

1. Bring 2 qt. **water** to a rolling boil in an 8-qt. pot over high heat. The water must be boiling before the **potatoes** go in. A boiling start frays the outside while the center stays intact.

2. Boil the **potatoes** and infuse the oil in the same window:

   (a) Add the **salt** and **baking soda** (*Small Bowl #1*) and the **potatoes** (*Large Bowl #1*). Stir so every chunk sits in the water. Add a splash of **water**, plus a pinch of **salt** and **baking soda**, when the top pieces stick out of the water. Return the pot to a boil, then lower the heat to a vigorous simmer.

   (b) As soon as the simmer is steady, pour the **olive oil**, **rosemary**, **garlic**, and **pepper** (*Small Bowl #2*) into a small saucepan. Set the empty bowl aside. Warm the oil over medium heat, stirring the whole time, until the **garlic** turns pale gold and the **rosemary** smells sweet, about *2–3 minutes*. Pull the pan off the heat at the first sign of gold. Dark garlic will turn the oil bitter. Strain the oil into the empty *Large Bowl #1*. Return the **garlic** and **rosemary** solids to *Small Bowl #2*.

(c) At about *10 minutes* after the boil returns, test a chunk. A knife should meet slight resistance in the center. The edges should look soft and frayed, and the piece should hold together when lifted. Give the pot another *1 minute* when the center is still hard. Keep those frayed edges on the chunk. Starch left behind in the water will not crisp.

3. Drain the **potatoes** and return them to the hot pot. Set the pot on the burner with the heat off. Let them steam for *2–3 minutes*, and shake the pot once. The surfaces should look matte, and the steam should thin out. Wet surfaces stay pale in the oven. Give them another *1 minute* while they still glisten. They should still be hot when you toss them.

4. Tip the **potatoes** into *Large Bowl #1*, onto the infused oil. Add the remaining 1/4 tsp. **black pepper** and a pinch of **salt**. Toss hard, shaking and turning, until a thick mashed-potato paste coats every chunk and the edges look shaggy. That paste becomes the crust. Add up to 1 Tbsp. more **olive oil** when the paste looks dry and powdery. Spoon off any oil that pools in the bottom of the bowl. A puddle will steam the bottoms.

5. Spread the **potatoes** in one layer on a bare half-sheet pan, with space between the chunks. Use a second pan when they touch. A crowded pan steams them. Roast at *450°F* (*400°F* convection) without moving them for *20 minutes*. The contact points should be golden, and a thin metal spatula should slide under each piece. Leave them another *5 minutes* while they still stick. Moving them early tears off the crust.

6. Loosen every piece, turn them, and shake the pan so the loose crumbs stay with the **potatoes**. Roast for *30–40 minutes* more, turning once about halfway. With two pans, swap racks when you turn them. The crust should be deep golden brown, with a few darker edges, and it should sound crisp when tapped. The center should give under a gentle press and look fluffy when you break one open. Continue in *5 minute* stretches while the crust is still pale. On convection, or with two pans, start checking at *30 minutes*.

7. Tip the **potatoes** into *Large Bowl #1*. Add the reserved **garlic** and **rosemary** (*Small Bowl #2*) and the **parsley** (*Small Bowl #3*). Toss. Taste. Add **salt** and **pepper** until the crust tastes seasoned. Serve at once. They are at their best in the first few minutes. The crust softens as they cool.

Equipment Required

- 8-qt. pot
- Colander
- 8-qt. or larger mixing bowl (*Large Bowl #1*)
- Small prep bowls (3)
- Small saucepan
- Fine-mesh strainer
- Half-sheet pan, 18 by 13 in. (a second pan when the chunks touch)
- Thin metal spatula
- Knife and cutting board
- Measuring cups and spoons
- Kitchen scale

Hints and Notes

Yield

- Serves 6–8 as a side.
- About ½ lb. of raw potato per person at 8 servings, and closer to ⅔ lb. at 6.

Mise en Place

- Heat the oven to *450°F* (*400°F* convection) before you start the pot. The boil and the roast should run as one stretch.
- *Large Bowl #1* — cut **potatoes**. After they go into the pot, strain the infused oil into this same bowl, then toss the drained **potatoes** in it.
- *Small Bowl #1* — boil seasonings: 2 Tbsp. **Diamond Crystal kosher salt**, ½ tsp. **baking soda**.
- *Small Bowl #2* — infusion: 6 Tbsp. **olive oil**, 1 Tbsp. **rosemary**, minced **garlic**, ¼ tsp. **black pepper**. After straining, this bowl holds the fried **garlic** and **rosemary**.
- *Small Bowl #3* — minced **parsley**.
- Have 1 Tbsp. extra **olive oil** within reach for the toss.

Ingredient Tips

- **Russets** give the crispest crust and a fluffy center. **Yukon Golds** roast darker, taste deeper, and stay a little less crisp. Use the same weight and cut.
- Cut chunks at least 2 inches across. A quarter of a medium potato, or a sixth or eighth of a large one, is the right size. Small pieces overcook before the crust browns.
- Weigh the boil **salt** at 1 oz. **Diamond Crystal** is about 2 Tbsp. **Morton kosher salt** is denser. Use about 1 Tbsp. plus 1 tsp. Morton for the same 1 oz.
- Keep the **baking soda** at ½ tsp. More of it tastes soapy and turns the outsides to mush.
- **Beef fat** or **duck fat** can replace the **olive oil** in the same amount. Either one makes a richer crust.
- Use fresh **rosemary** and **parsley**. Dried herbs scorch in the oil and taste dusty at the end.

Preparation Tips

- The alkaline boil breaks down the outside of the **potato** faster than the center. That rough coat is what crisps.
- Leave the sheet bare. Parchment keeps the paste from frying against the metal.
- The first *20 minutes* set the bottom crust. Wait until a spatula slides under a piece before you turn the pan.
- Browning time varies with the potato and the pan. Trust the color and the sound of the crust more than the clock.
- Two pans brown faster than one full pan. Check them at the short end of the *30–40 minute* range.
- Break one **potato** open near the end. The center should look steamy and fluffy, and the shell should shatter.

Make Ahead & Storage

- Cook from the boil through the roast in one stretch. The paste browns less evenly after it sits.
- Serve within a few minutes. The crust softens as the steam from the center moves outward.
- Refrigerate leftovers up to *3 days*.
- Reheat uncovered on a sheet pan at *450°F* for *10–15 minutes*, until the crust crackles again. They will be good, and they will be less crisp than the first service.

Serving Suggestions

- Serve straight from the pan, beside roast meat, a fried egg, or a sharp salad.
- The peak is the first few minutes out of the oven.
- A squeeze of lemon or a pinch of chile flake can go on at the table. Add either one after the **parsley** toss.